

Elderly consumers in marketing research: A systematic literature review and directions for future research

Hanna Berg¹  | Karina T. Liljedal^{1,2} 

¹Center for Consumer Marketing, Stockholm School of Economics, Stockholm, Sweden

²Center for Retailing, Stockholm School of Economics, Stockholm, Sweden

Correspondence

Hanna Berg, Center for Consumer Marketing, Stockholm School of Economics, Box 6501, Stockholm SE-113 83, Sweden.
Email: hanna.berg@hhs.se

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Abstract

This paper reports a theme-based structured systematic literature review of the growing body of marketing research about elderly consumers. By synthesizing, explicating, and relating this research, the paper offers a structured view of the past and present state of the research field and integrates it into a theoretical framework. The literature review was based on 209 marketing research articles published from the early 1970s to 2021. It identified 13 research topics, which were subsequently grouped into three themes: (1) describing and defining the elderly market segment, (2) age changes and the elderly consumer, and (3) marketing responses of elderly consumers. Based on these themes, the paper presents a theoretical framework and provides directions for future marketing research on elderly consumers. The systematic literature review thus provides clarity to a wide and interdisciplinary research field, facilitating its continued growth.

KEYWORDS

consumer aging, elderly consumers, marketing research, systematic literature review

1 | INTRODUCTION

Elderly consumers have been a topic of marketing research since at least the 1970s (Mason & Smith, 1974; Phillips & Sternthal, 1977). Since then, there has been a moderately sized but continuous stream of marketing research on elderly consumers. Many researchers in this field have noted that elderly consumers now constitute a larger share of all consumers than ever before due to the rapidly aging populations in many countries (Guido et al., 2021; Sudbury-Riley et al., 2015; Tootelian & Varshney, 2010). This literature is, however, fragmented and interdisciplinary, and there is a need for a comprehensive and current literature review to clarify the past and present state of the research. It is precisely this gap which we aim to fill with this paper. There have been some notable previous literature reviews concerning elderly consumers, but most of these have focused on specific research topics, such as the decision making (Yoon et al., 2005, 2009) and information processing (John & Cole, 1986; Phillips &

Sternthal, 1977) of elderly consumers, as well as the methodological and theoretical issues surrounding research about elderly consumers (Moschis, 2012). Other previous literature reviews were comprehensive, but published several decades ago (Moschis, 1994; Tongren, 1988).

These previous literature reviews differ from the present paper in several ways. First, in this literature review we include some research topics that have been omitted in previous literature reviews, such as how elderly consumers respond to various aspects of marketing, including advertising, retailing, and sustainability. Additionally, we aim to provide a current and comprehensive overview of the past and present marketing research about elderly consumers. This is needed due to the rapid growth of both the elderly consumer group and the marketing research literature that has studied it. In fact, according to data from the United Nations (2019) World Population Prospects, by 2050, one in four persons living in Europe and North America could be aged 65 or older. On average, elderly consumers have relatively

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large disposable incomes and many of them are active consumers with plenty of free time (Sudbury & Simcock, 2009; Swimberghe et al., 2018). For example, the UN estimated already in 2008 that roughly half of all the discretionary income in the U.S. was earned by people over the age of 65 (Swimberghe et al., 2018; United Nations, 2008). Elderly consumers also control a large part of the family financial stock and hold high purchasing power (Asebedo, Seay, et al., 2019; Asebedo, Wilmarth, et al., 2019). Unsurprisingly, the growth and importance of this consumer group has inspired an increase in the marketing research articles focusing on elderly consumers.

We use a theme-based approach (Paul & Criado, 2020; Snyder, 2019) to a structured systematic literature review and focus on the peer-reviewed articles that constitute the basis of the marketing research domain. By synthesizing, explicating, and relating this research, new insights about the research field are provided (Baumeister & Leary, 1997; MacInnis, 2011; Palmatier et al., 2018). Specifically, we have identified three themes in our systematic literature review: (1) describing and defining the elderly consumer group, (2) age changes and the elderly consumers, and (3) marketing responses of elderly consumers. These themes in turn encompass 13 specific research topics. Based on the three themes and the research topics encompassed in them, we propose a framework and directions for future research, thereby aiming to contribute to the future growth of this important and timely research area (Paul & Criado, 2020). This paper thus adds to marketing research by providing a comprehensive and structured overview of the five decades of marketing research on elderly consumers to date, from the 1970s to the present.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. The next section of this paper describes the methodology used for the theme-based structured systematic literature review reported in this paper. This section also includes a short description of our data, including a chronological analysis, a geographical analysis of where the research to date has been conducted, and an overview of the most frequently occurring journals in our analysis. In the section that follows, the themes identified in our systematic literature review are presented and discussed, followed by a section presenting the theoretical framework proposed in this paper. Based on the framework, we subsequently provide an outline of our suggestions for future research. Finally, the last section of the paper offers a conclusion of the theme-based structured systematic literature review reported in this paper and the directions for future research.

2 | METHODOLOGY

This literature review was conducted using a theme-based structured systematic approach, following the guidelines outlined by Paul and Criado (2020). This structured approach allowed us to study a broad research field and track its development over time. A systematic approach was used to minimize the risks of bias and to provide reliable findings (Moher et al., 2009; Snyder, 2019). Given the broad base

of marketing research that has studied elderly consumers, our aim with this literature review is to provide an understanding of this complex body of literature. To this end, *themes* were used as a means of analysis instead of, for example, effect sizes, which are sometimes used in other systematic reviews or meta-analyses (Snyder, 2019; Wong et al., 2013). In a thematic literature review, the themes can be a way of linking together many studies on different topics or domains, to reinterpret findings and contributions, or to connect previously disparate studies or research fields (Baumeister & Leary, 1997; Paul & Criado, 2020). This allows for summarizing and explicating the literature, as well as relating different parts of the literature by integrating them into categories or themes, by identifying patterns and key underlying properties (MacInnis, 2011). In line with previous systematic literature reviews on other marketing topics, such as omnichannel retailing (Mishra et al., 2021) and social media influencer marketing (Vrontis et al., 2021), we also propose a framework and suggest directions for future research based on our thematic analysis. Our review can thus be categorized as what Paul and Criado (2020) describes as a review aiming for model/framework development (p. 2). Such frameworks are typically either derived based on the reviewed research literature or an established template for frameworks such as the ADO (Antecedents, Decisions and Outcome) framework (Paul & Benito, 2018; Paul & Criado, 2020). For the purpose of our literature review, developing a new framework based on the themes available in the marketing research literature on elderly consumers was deemed necessary to better structure and present the rich and varied research (in line with e.g., Rebouças & Soares, 2021; White et al., 2019).

2.1 | Selection of journals and articles

Our systematic literature review covers the latest five decades of marketing research articles on elderly consumers published in academic journals. We did not limit on our article search in terms of publication date, but included all articles that matched our selection criteria. As a first step, three selection criteria were established for selecting the articles to be included in our analysis. The first criterion was that the articles should be academic journal articles published in English. The second criterion was that the articles should be published in peer-reviewed journals included in the Academic Journal Guide (published by CABS, the Chartered Association on Business Schools). This selection criterion has previously been used in several recent literature reviews (Paul & Criado, 2020). The third criterion was that the articles should be marketing articles, published in marketing, general management, sector studies or information management journals, because this is where marketing research on elderly consumers is typically published. Articles from any year of publication were included in our searches. To ensure that all relevant articles were identified, the search was carried out using nine article databases: ABI Inform/Proquest One Business, Business Source Premier, Emerald, JSTOR, Google Scholar, Sage Publications, Science Direct, Social Science Research Network, and Taylor and Francis Online. The database searches were conducted during December 2019, January 2020, and April 2021. The

search terms used were *elderly consumer**, *senior consumer**, and *aging consumer** because these are most typically used in marketing research on elderly consumers. We initially tried additional search terms, such as *mature consumer** and *older consumer**, but these searches only replicated results already matched by the previous search terms. The databases vary in terms of the degree to which searches can be specified and narrowed down. The search terms were used to search abstracts, titles, and keywords, when possible, but in many of the article databases (such as Google Scholar), search results had to be produced based on matches anywhere in the text. The database searches produced a wide range of results; the search term *elderly consumer** generated between 16 and 930,000 matches depending on the database used, *senior consumer** generated between 21 and 1,850,000 matches, and *aging consumer** between 17 and 907,000 matches. Search protocols were used to log all database searches and results. To the extent possible, we avoided adding duplicates to the list of articles. Upon completion of the article searches, 27 remaining duplicates were, however, found and removed. This generated a list of 380 articles. Due to the large number of matches found for the search terms in some databases, only the articles that met our inclusion criteria were listed and proceeded with.

2.1.1 | Inclusion criteria

A coding scheme was created to identify those articles that did not meet the inclusion criteria and should therefore be excluded from the literature review. This process resulted in four categories of articles that did not meet the inclusion criteria and were subsequently removed from our literature review. The first category consisted of articles that should not have been included at all, because they did

not concern elderly consumers. For example, the search term *senior consumer** also generated articles based on interviews with senior managers and their views on consumer products and services. This category also included other types of published material, such as book reviews, that are not considered academic journal articles. The second category contained research about aging in contexts that do not include consumers. The third category consisted of articles that focused only on organizational decisions and strategies in different areas concerning the elderly. The fourth category consisted of articles which examined how other consumer groups respond to representations of the elderly in advertising. After eliminating these categories, 209 articles remained and were subsequently analyzed. Figure 1 illustrates the process leading up to the final number of articles.

2.1.2 | Academic journals and geographical distribution

The 209 articles in our literature review were published in 59 different journals. Table 1 illustrates the most frequently occurring journals in our literature review.

Further, the geographical distribution of the reviewed articles was also analyzed, indicating that the 209 articles were mostly based on research conducted in the U.S. and in Europe. The geographical distribution was analyzed based on where the data for each article had been collected or, if this was not specified in the article, the geographical location of the academic institution that the authors were affiliated with at the time of each article publication. Conceptual papers that did not report any data were categorized in line with the author affiliations. Table 2 illustrates the most frequently occurring countries in our analysis of the research articles.

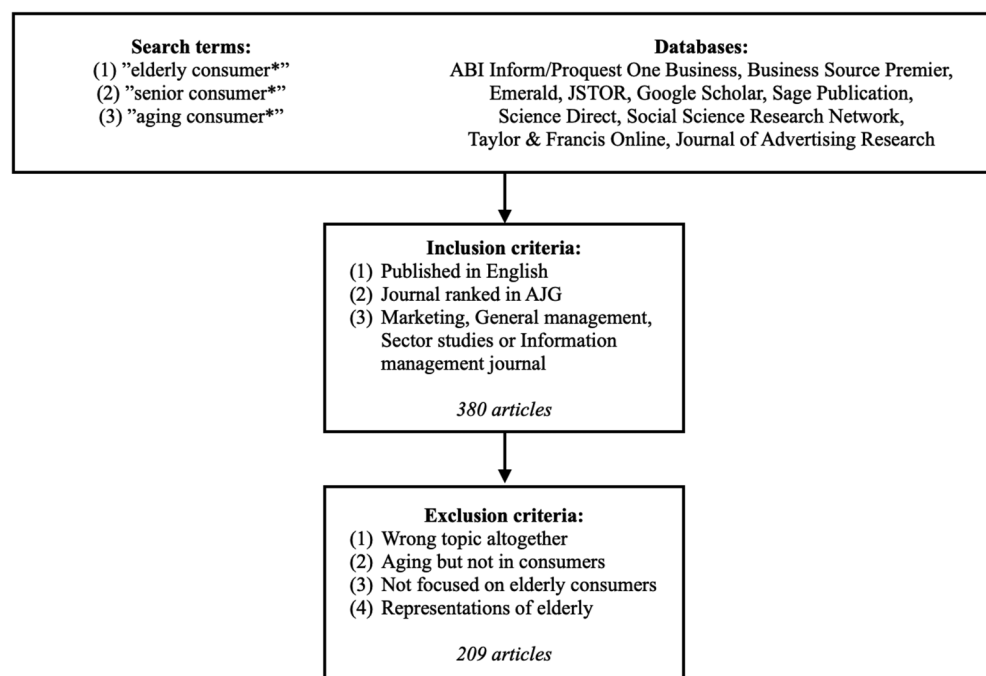


FIGURE 1 Illustration of the research article selection process

TABLE 1 List of journals with three or more articles included in our study

Journal	No. of articles
Journal of Consumer Marketing	33
Journal of Services Marketing	13
Psychology & Marketing	11
Journal of Consumer Research	10
Journal of Marketing Management	10
International Journal of Consumer Studies	9
Journal of Consumer Affairs	9
Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services	8
International Journal of Retail & Distribution Management	5
International Review of Retail Distribution and Consumer Research	5
Journal of Business Research	5
Journal of Fashion Marketing and Management	5
Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science	5
Journal of Business Ethics	4
Journal of Consumer Psychology	4
Journal of Financial Services Marketing	4
Journal of Marketing Research	4
Journal of Vacation Marketing	4
International Journal of Bank Marketing	3
Journal of Advertising Research	3
Journal of Public Policy & Marketing	3
Journal of Retailing	3
Marketing Letters	3
Qualitative Market Research	3

TABLE 2 List of geographical representation in the marketing research on elderly consumers

Country	No. of articles
The United States	110
United Kingdom	29
France	13
Australia	8
Finland	7
South Korea	7
Italy	5
Germany	4
Canada	3
China	3
India	2
Portugal	2
Thailand	2
Other (countries with 1 or fewer articles)	14
Total	209

2.2 | Method of analysis

As a first step in our analysis, we individually read all 209 articles and sought to identify research topics in the literature for the purpose of creating a theoretical and domain-based framework of the marketing research on elderly consumers. The specific research topics covered in the articles are described in more detail below as part of our analysis. After this first categorization of the articles, we carried out a short chronological analysis of the articles based on the year that they were first published (reported below). As a final step in the analysis, we iteratively read and coded the articles into themes based on the research topics covered in each article. All themes were typically covered in more than one paper and the article categorization thus “becomes a system by which different categories relate to other categories” (Snyder et al., 2016, p. 2403). Both authors coded all articles to ensure alignment with the themes and article adherence to the themes. This resulted in the 13 research topics that were grouped into three overarching themes.

2.3 | Chronological distribution of the articles

A chronological analysis of the articles shows that the publication of research articles about elderly consumers has been continuous since the 1970s, as illustrated in Figure 2 below. Interestingly, the number of published articles has increased over time, mirroring an increased research interest (although some of this increase might also be an effect of the general increase in the publication of scientific articles).

As described below, the chronological analysis also shows that the research topics covered in the articles have differed over time.

2.3.1 | 1970s–1980s

Our literature review contains 25 articles published between 1972 and 1989. Approximately half of these discuss the “senior market segment” in terms of demographics and behavior (Fox & French, 1985; Lumpkin, 1985). Some of the other articles examine differences between the information processing of elderly and younger consumers (John & Cole, 1986; Phillips & Sternthal, 1977), or specifically study elderly consumers and new technologies (Gilly & Zeithaml, 1985; Schiffman, 1972) or elderly consumers in a retailing context (e.g., Greco, 1986; Mason & Smith, 1974).

2.3.2 | 1990s

The literature review contains 36 articles published between 1990 and 1999. During this decade, the literature was still dominated by studies that describe the elderly market segment and the behavior of elderly consumers (Abdel-Ghany & Sharpe, 1997; Moschis, 1994). Newer research topics included research about the cognitive differences between elderly and other consumers, such as differences in decision making and how consumers process marketing messages (Cole & Gaeth, 1990; Yoon, 1997).

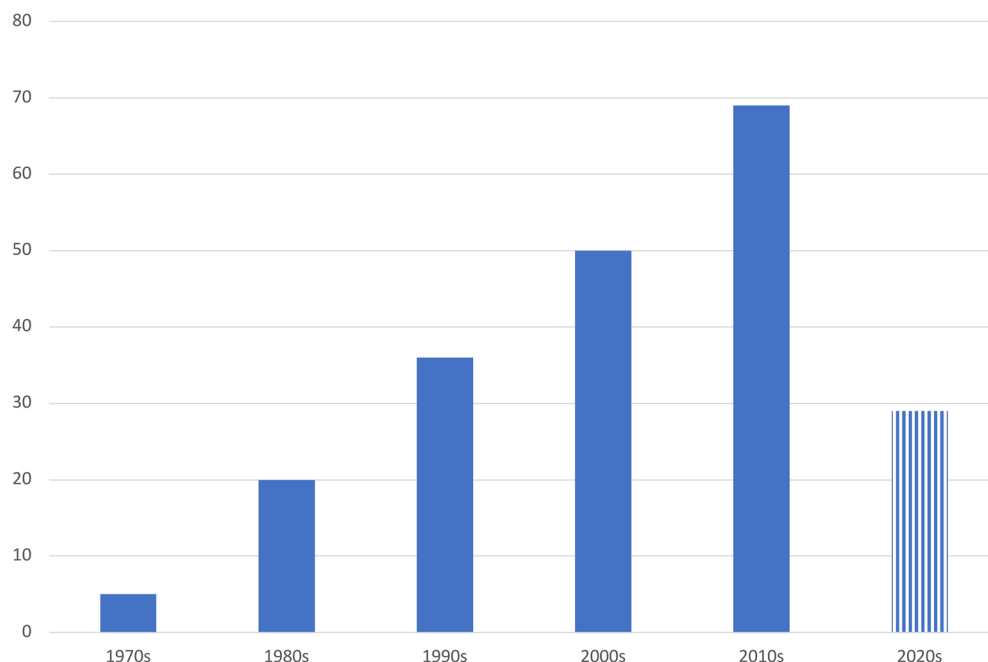


FIGURE 2 Number of articles published on elderly consumers in marketing, per decade (until April 2021)

2.3.3 | 2000s

The literature search identified 50 articles published between 2000 and 2009. Some of these articles discuss the elderly consumer group in terms of their cognitive age as opposed to their chronological age (i.e., the self-perceived age of the elderly consumers; Catterall & Maclaran, 2001; Szmigin & Carrigan, 2001). The first articles about the baby boomer generation as elderly consumers (Dann, 2007) were also published.

2.3.4 | 2010s

The literature search includes 69 articles published between 2010 and 2019. During this period, the articles focused on the responses to stereotypes (Bae et al., 2018; Groeppel-Klein et al., 2017) and consumer vulnerabilities (Berg, 2015; Roy & Sanyal, 2017). There were also more articles about consumer responses to different aspects of the marketing offer, such as service encounters (Grougiou & Pettigrew, 2011; Plaud & Guillemot, 2015) and interactions with brands (Jahn et al., 2012; Lambert-Pandraud & Laurent, 2010). Some recent articles also examine elderly consumers in terms of their behavior related to sustainability (Guiot et al., 2019) and sustainable consumption (Sudbury Riley et al., 2012).

2.3.5 | 2020–2021

There were also 29 articles published from 2020 until the time of our article search (April 2021). Most of these recent articles focus on consumer responses to different aspects of marketing, such as services (Kuppelwieser & Klaus, 2020) and new technologies (Bae et al., 2021).

Some current developments during the last few years, such as the COVID-19 pandemic, had yet to be described in the published marketing research on elderly consumers at the time of our analysis. These are therefore missing from our analysis.

2.4 | Threshold age for the elderly consumer group

Definitions of the threshold age for the elderly consumer group vary among the articles in our literature review, although the most common age for when a consumer is considered elderly is 65 years old (Abdel-Ghany & Sharpe, 1997; Drolet et al., 2007; East et al., 2014; Lumpkin, 1985; Phillips & Sternthal, 1977; Tootelian & Varshney, 2010; Williams & Drolet, 2005; Yoon et al., 2009). This standard for threshold age is confirmed in an early review article by Tongren (1988), who found that most published studies about older consumers identified the group as people 65 years or older. The choice of 65 years as the threshold age is sometimes explained by its common use as a retirement age (Catterall & Maclaran, 2001). However, several of the articles in our literature review use lower threshold ages, such as 50 years (Jahn et al., 2012; Sudbury & Simcock, 2009), 55 years (Sherman et al., 2001; Stephens, 1991), and 60 years (Lambert-Pandraud et al., 2005; Swimberghe et al., 2018).

3 | THEMATIC ANALYSIS

In our thematic analysis of the articles, we identified 13 research topics in the literature. These topics were grouped into three themes: describing and defining the elderly consumer group, age changes and the elderly consumers, and marketing responses of elderly consumers. In some articles, several of the themes were covered, but in our

TABLE 3 List of references grouped into themes & research topics

Themes	Research topics	No. of articles	% of articles	References
Theme 1: Describing and defining the elderly consumer group	Describing the elderly consumers as a market segment	17	8,1%	Fox and French (1985); Lumpkin et al. (1985); Greco (1987); Lumpkin and Hite (1988); Sorce et al. (1989); Leventhal (1990); Leventhal (1991); Moschis et al. (1993); Moschis (1994); Abdel-Ghany and Sharpe (1997); Leventhal (1997); Ahmad (2002); Sudbury and Simcock (2009); Ferguson and Brohaugh (2010); Tootelian and Varshney (2010); Sudbury et al. (2014); Sudbury-Riley (2016)
	Defining aging & the elderly consumer	16	7,7%	Schewe (1988); Tongren (1988); Burnett (1989), (1991), (1996); Stephens (1991); Szmigin and Carrigan (2000); Catterall and Maclaran (2001); Szmigin and Carrigan (2001); Moschis and Mathur (2006); Dann (2007); Amatulli et al. (2015), (2018); Sudbury-Riley et al. (2015); Thuckavadee et al. (2018); Marjanen et al. (2019)
	Old age identities & subsegments of the elderly consumers	11	5,3%	Lumpkin and Greenberg (1982); Schiffman and Sherman (1991); Vitell et al. (1991); Schewe and Balazs (1992); Tepper (1994); Alreck (2000); Sherman et al. (2001); Hyun-Mee and Miller (2006); Schau et al. (2009); Fregolente et al. (2019); Kuppelwieser and Klaus (2021)
	<i>Theme 1 total:</i>	44	21,1%	
Theme 2: Age changes and the elderly consumers	Cognitive changes with age	20	9,6%	Phillips and Sternthal (1977); John and Cole (1986); Cole and Houston (1987); Gaeth and Heath (1987); Cole and Gaeth (1990); Ensley and Pride (1991); Cole and Balasubramanian (1993); Guy et al. (1994); Sorce (1995); Yoon (1997); Laufer et al. (2005); Yoon et al. (2005), (2009); Simcock et al. (2006); Cole et al. (2008), (2009); Goldberg (2009); Sternthal and Bonezzi (2009); Silvera et al. (2012); Guido et al. (2021)
	Vulnerability & consumption ensembles	12	5,7%	Lumpkin and Hunt (1989); Gibler et al. (1998); Lee and Geistfeld (1999); Ramsey et al. (2007); Griffiths and Harmon (2011); Barnhart and Peñaloza (2013); Annunziata et al. (2015); Berg (2015); Ford et al. (2016); Roy and Sanyal (2017); Ho and Shirahada (2020); LaBarge and Pyle (2020)
	Reactions to aging	4	1,9%	Loroz (2004); Groeppel-Klein et al. (2017); Bae et al. (2018); Moscato and Ozanne (2019)
	<i>Theme 2 total:</i>	36	17,2%	
Theme 3: Marketing responses of elderly consumers	Elderly consumers and advertising	10	4,8%	Stephens (1982); Benet et al. (1993); Williams and Drolet (2005); Drolet et al. (2007); Codruta Micu and Chowdhury (2010); Jayanti (2010); Sudbury-Riley and Edgar (2016); Albouy and Jean-Marc (2018); Chevalier and Moal-Ulvoas (2018); Lee and Haley (2020)
	Elderly consumers and brands	8	3,8%	Jayanti et al. (2004); Lambert-Pandraud et al. (2005); Lambert-Pandraud and Laurent (2010); Jahn et al. (2012); Ilicic et al. (2016); Swimberghe et al. (2018); Phua et al. (2020); Halwani (2021)
	Elderly consumers and services	29	13,9%	LaForge (1989); Sirgy et al. (1991); Smith (1993); Kang and Ridgway (1996); Chevalier (2003); Moschis et al. (2003); Pettigrew et al. (2003); Myers and Lumbers (2008); Grougiou and Pettigrew (2009); Karahasanović et al. (2009); Stone (2009); Grougiou and Pettigrew (2011); Lee et al. (2012); Milner and Rosenstreich (2013); East et al. (2014); Kim and Jang (2015); Plaud and Guillemot (2015); Altinay et al. (2019); Cosma et al. (2019); Kim and Jang (2019); Chaouali et al. (2020); Guido et al. (2020); Henkel et al. (2020); Kuppelwieser and Klaus (2020); Babin et al. (2021); Bateson (2021); Prattharanitcha and Moschis (2021); Westberg et al. (2021); Wu et al. (2021)

(Continues)

TABLE 3 (Continued)

Themes	Research topics	No. of articles	% of articles	References
	Elderly consumers and retailing	37	17,7%	Mason and Smith (1974); Gillett and Schneider (1978); Mason and Bearden (1979); Zeithaml and Fuerst (1983); Lumpkin et al. (1985); Tantiwong and Wilton (1985); Greco (1986); Burt and Gabbott (1995); Keillor et al. (1996); Oates et al. (1996); Sansgiry and Cady (1996); Johnson-Hillery et al. (1997); Reisenwitz and Wimbish (1997); Miller et al. (1998); Shufeldt et al. (1998); Moschis et al. (2004); Pettigrew et al. (2005); Boyd Thomas and Lee Okleshen Peters (2009); Meneely, Burns, and Strugnell (2009); Meneely, Strugnell, and Burns (2009); Kohijoki (2011); Moschis et al. (2011); Peters et al. (2011); Teller and Gittenberger (2011); Risius et al. (2012); Kohijoki and Marjanen (2013); Teller et al. (2013); Yin et al. (2013); Chattaraman et al. (2014); Omar et al. (2014); Marjanen et al. (2016); Oeser et al. (2018); Rahman and Yu (2018); Baek (2020); Dorie et al. (2019); Townsend et al. (2019); Roy et al. (2020)
	Elderly consumers and tourism	17	8,1%	Mathur et al. (1998); Littrell et al. (2004); Lee and Tideswell (2005); Hunter-Jones and Blackburn (2007); Lehto et al. (2008); Glover and Prideaux (2009); González et al. (2009); Le Serre and Chevalier (2012); Tiago et al. (2016); Le Serre et al. (2017); Shavanddasht (2018); Kim and Kim (2020); Pestana et al. (2020); Zuo and Lai (2020); Moal (2021); Pan et al. (2021); Sie et al. (2021)
	Elderly consumers and new technologies	24	11,5%	Schiffman (1972); Gilly and Zeithaml (1985); Lunsford and Burnett (1992); Mathur (1999); Trocchia and Janda (2000); Eastman and Iyer (2005); Eastman and Iyer (2005); Laukkanen et al. (2007); Niemelä-Nyrhinen (2007); Reisenwitz et al. (2007); Hough and Kobylanski (2009); Chattaraman et al. (2011); Fowler et al. (2015); Nikou (2015); Harris et al. (2016); Mostaghel (2016); Choudrie et al. (2018); Chaouali and Souiden (2019); Nunan and Di Domenico (2019); Abouzahra and Ghasemaghaei (2021); Bae et al. (2021); Bianchi (2021); Park et al. (2021); Rajaobeline et al. (2021)
	Elderly consumers and sustainability	4	1,9%	Sudbury Riley et al. (2012); Guiot et al. (2019); Kim and Jin (2019); Nam (2020)
	<i>Theme 3 total:</i>	129	61,7%	

analysis, we allocated these articles to themes based on the theme to which each article contributed the most. Table 3 illustrates the three themes, as well as the research topics that contribute to them.

3.1 | The first theme: Describing and defining the elderly consumer group

The first theme is focused on describing and defining the elderly consumers and the elderly consumer group, often in terms of the market segment that they constitute and its potential. This theme was prominent in the research from the 1970s, although during the last few decades the focus has moved from more classical segmentation studies to articles examining different ways to define the consumer group. Some later works have also attempted to describe elderly consumers in term of their consumer identities. This theme is the focus of about one-fifth of the articles in our analysis and is made up of three research topics: describing the elderly consumers as a market

segment, defining aging and the elderly consumer, and old age identities and subsegments of the elderly consumers. Although there may be some overlap between these research topics, the main difference between the topics lies in the focus of the research contributing to them. That is, while the first research topic highlights the elderly consumers as a market segment separate from other market segments, the second topic is more concerned with how we should define who belongs to the elderly consumer group. The third topic focuses more on the identities of the elderly consumers and emphasizes that there are subsegments within this large and heterogenous group of elderly consumers.

3.1.1 | Describing the elderly consumers as a market segment

Chronological age has long been used as a basis for market segmentation (Fox & French, 1985), and this is clearly reflected in the analyzed

articles. Many of the analyzed articles describe the elderly market segment and its potential for marketers, especially from the 1980s forward (Fox & French, 1985; Greco, 1987). Many of these articles take a classical market segmentation approach and some describe attempts to divide the elderly consumer group into smaller market segments using statistical techniques, such as cluster analysis with demographic or survey data (Lumpkin, 1985; Sudbury & Simcock, 2009). Other articles simply segment the elderly consumer group using demographic segmenting variables. For example, Abdel-Ghany and Sharpe (1997) found differences in spending patterns between what they label as the young-old (65 to 74-years-old) and old-old (75-years-old or older) consumers, using chronological age as a proxy for life cycle stage. Several articles use this type of segmenting, although the age ranges and labels vary, adding to the body of knowledge about how consumers and their behavior change and transform over the many years they are considered elderly consumers.

Many early articles discuss the entry of the “baby boomer” generation (born approximately between 1946 and 1964) into the elderly consumer group. Several point out that as this happens, the elderly will gradually make up an increasingly large proportion of the market in many countries, and thus, marketers need to realize the market potential of the group (Ferguson & Brohaugh, 2010). Whether discussing the baby boomer generation or not, the research articles covering this research topic seem to agree that the elderly consumer market segment is a growing and financially strong market segment. Longer life expectancies and the large post-war generations, combined with declining birth rates, are important factors that contribute to the relative growth of the market segment compared with other consumer segments. Thus, the articles in this research topic typically stress the importance of the elderly consumer segment based on its sheer size and implied financial importance for marketers. Some articles written in the 1980s suggested that elderly consumers were finally about to get the attention from marketers that they deserved, because by then 11.5 percent of the U.S. population were over 65 years old and the consumer group was growing at twice the rate of the population as a whole (Lumpkin, 1985; Sorce et al., 1989). Abdel-Ghany and Sharpe (1997) noted that by 1990, the elderly consumers had reached 12.6 percent of the U.S. population and a continued growth was predicted when the baby boomers entered the group. In the early 2010s, U.S. baby boomers accounted for 78 million and controlled almost 75 percent of the personal wealth in the U.S., spending more than 1 trillion USD annually as consumers (Tootelian & Varshney, 2010). The articles published in the early 2000s also increasingly included global or international demographical data for the elderly consumer group (e.g., Ahmad, 2002; Sudbury & Simcock, 2009). Still, none of these articles have yet provided any comprehensive information about the global size and market potential of the elderly consumer segment.

This research topic also includes articles that attempt to map the preferences (Lumpkin & Hite, 1988), attitudes (Sudbury et al., 2014), and behaviors (Tootelian & Varshney, 2010) of the elderly consumer group. Included are also a few review articles, such as Tongren (1988) and Moschis (1994, 2012). Together, the analyzed articles paint a

picture of a growing demographic group with substantial resources, representing a lucrative market segment that marketers would be wise not to ignore. At the same time, the elderly consumer group is large and heterogeneous. There are substantial differences between how, for example, the young-old and the old-old act as consumers (e.g., in terms of spending; Abdel-Ghany & Sharpe, 1997). The consumer group is also constantly changing as new generational cohorts enter it (Tootelian & Varshney, 2010). As the baby boomers age, the preferences and expectations of the elderly consumer segment will change from those held by previous generations of elderly consumers, such as the silent generation (Ferguson & Brohaugh, 2010; Sudbury-Riley et al., 2015).

3.1.2 | Defining aging and the elderly consumer

If the first research topic in this theme centers around describing the elderly consumer segment (for example in terms of market segment size and importance), the second research topic represents different attempts at defining the elderly consumer group (as in who should be considered part of this market segment and its subsegments). One way of defining the group is, of course, by chronological age. As mentioned in the method section, 65 years seems to be the most used threshold age (Catterall & Maclaran, 2001). Some articles also examine retirement as a criterion for defining the elderly consumer group (Burnett, 1989). Relatedly, Thuckavadee et al. (2018) used gerontographics to explain consumer behavior in elderly consumers. Another way of defining the elderly consumer group is by generation or cohort, which are groups of consumers born during a specific period of time. People born in the same age cohort or generation share many life-shaping experiences that are often linked to similar worldviews and consumption preferences (Yoon et al., 2009). While the chronological age of a person changes constantly with time, the cohort that a person belongs to stays the same throughout life, and members of the same cohorts often display many similarities in how they act as consumers (Marjanen et al., 2019; Moschis, 2012). The baby boomer generation is one such generational cohort, described by Dann (2007) as the first “branded” generation which may come to place other demands on marketers than previous cohorts of elderly consumers. The baby boomers were the first generation of teenagers. They came of age in a world that was very different from that faced by previous generations, defined by less traditional values, the growth of mass media, rapid technological development, and a wider access to higher education (Sudbury-Riley et al., 2015).

Another way of defining the elderly consumer group is by their cognitive age (Barak & Schiffman, 1981). Cognitive age is defined as the self-perceived (or subjective) age of a person which is part of the self-concept of that person (Stephens, 1991). Cognitive age varies with some consumer characteristics, so that people with low incomes and low education tend to have higher cognitive ages than people of the same chronological ages with high incomes and educational levels (Catterall & Maclaran, 2001; Stephens, 1991). Szmigin and Carrigan (2001) found cognitively young elderly consumers, defined as

consumers whose cognitive age is more than 12 years lower than their chronological age, to be active consumers who are very much a part of the modern consumer society. Moschis and Mathur (2006) found that cognitive age is positively related to interest in senior discounts and sensitivity to age stereotypes in ads, but only in the “young-old” category of elderly consumers. The cognitive age is lower than the chronological age for most elderly consumers, although the size of the difference varies within the group (Sherman et al., 2001). Sudbury-Riley et al. (2015) were able to identify a “young at heart” subsegment among the baby boomers in four countries (UK, Germany, Hungary, and Japan), with significantly lower cognitive ages than biological ages. The authors also found a general youth bias in the baby boomer segment of all four countries, meaning that the average cognitive age was lower than the average chronological age.

Catterall and Maclaran (2001) questioned some of the underlying assumptions behind the concept of cognitive age, arguing that cognitive age is not a static self-perception but rather a mutable social construct. From this perspective, the cognitive age of a person is not only determined by self-perception but also, for example, by attitudes toward aging. These authors proposed that although the concepts of age and aging are related to time and the biological aging processes, their meaning is socially and historically determined. Catterall and Maclaran (2001) also argued that cognitive age is of limited use to consumer research as it displays only a low correlation with the actual behavior of elderly consumers. This view of cognitive age is partly supported by Amatulli et al. (2018), who demonstrate that social cues can trigger an identity threat in elderly consumers, which has a negative effect on their expressed cognitive age. Kuppelwieser and Klaus (2021) recently questioned the usefulness of the cognitive age concept, arguing that age should be viewed as a construct and not as a characteristic and that future time perspective (FTP) is a more promising concept for future research. Future time perspective is a construct that is less related to chronological age and more focused on the time that people believe they have left in their lives (Kuppelwieser & Klaus, 2020). Relatedly, Moschis (2012) argued for the use of a life-course paradigm when studying the behavior of elderly consumers. It should be noted, however, that the literature on cognitive age does not typically focus on cognitive changes with age, which is a research topic discussed in more detail below in section 3.2.1 on cognitive changes with age.

3.1.3 | Old age identities and subsegments of the elderly consumers

The third research topic in this theme is focused on studying consumer identities in the elderly consumer group. In the articles which focus on this topic, the elderly consumers are not described as a market segment or defined as a group; rather, consumer identities within the group are explored in more detail. These identities are sometimes related to subsegments of the elderly group but are described more in terms of consumer culture and consumer identities than in terms of more tangible consumer characteristics. One such subculture that has

been studied in a number of articles is the new-age elderly. This consumer group first appeared in the literature in the early 1990s and is described as a group whose values differ from the traditional elderly in their more youthful orientation and in emphasizing novel experiences and personal challenges in their consumption rather than the accumulation of possessions (Schiffman & Sherman, 1991). The new-age elderly are more optimistic about their financial situations than more traditional elderly consumers; they seek out more information, are more novelty seeking, and have lower cognitive ages (Sherman et al., 2001). Although the appearance of the new-age elderly has sometimes been taken as a sign that we are approaching a more ageless society, Alreck (2000) showed that there were no notable changes in age role norms and in adherence to age role norms between 1980 and 2000 and was unable to identify a new-age elderly segment among elderly consumers. However, elderly consumers do not always accept an old age identity. Tepper (1994) emphasized the importance of labeling processes in how older people relate to age segmentation and described how the acceptance of offers that impart age segmentation cues (e.g., senior discounts) can lead to self-devaluation and perceived social stigma in elderly consumers. Schewe and Balazs (1992) use role theory to describe how marketing and consumption can help elderly transition into new roles during aging, such as grandparent, caregiver, retirement, or widowhood. Schau et al. (2009) describe how elderly consumers may experience a resurgence of identity-inspired consumption in their retirement years as an “identity renaissance.”

3.1.4 | Discussion of the first theme: Describing and defining the elderly consumer group

The articles focusing on the first theme attempt to describe and define the elderly consumer group, or different subsegments of it. Consumer identities within the group are also explored. The emphasis in the research literature focused on this theme is on finding and defining similarities between the members of the elderly consumer group. One issue with many of these articles is that, although they were very relevant at the time they were written, they tend to age as fast as the elderly consumers they are describing. The demographics and consumer characteristics described in the articles change over time, with new cohorts entering the group. For example, many of the articles describe a future in which the baby boomer generation would enter into the elderly consumer group (Dann, 2007; Ferguson & Brohaugh, 2010). In 2021, the oldest baby boomers will be 75 years old, meaning that they will soon be part of the old-old sub-segment of the group. The older articles also (naturally) fail to consider many recent events that have influenced the elderly consumer group, such as the ongoing COVID-19 pandemic. Only a few of the articles that we analyzed take into account and discuss the time period in which the article was written, and the data were collected.

Further, as evidenced by the recent articles by Kuppelwieser and Klaus (2020, 2021), there is still an ongoing debate on how to best define aging in the context of elderly consumers. The

introduction of concepts such as the future time perspective (FTP) complicate the discourse further. Based on this construct, for example, a chronologically young person with a life-threatening disease could have a shorter FTP than an elderly person. The FTP construct does, however, seem to hold some promise when it comes to predicting consumer behavior. Finally, the articles in this theme indicate the problems that arise when elderly consumers are described and defined as a market segment based solely on their age, when research increasingly indicates the richness and variation within the elderly consumer group. The research on old age identity also overlaps with the research in the next theme, on reactions to aging and how elderly consumers respond to different aspects of aging. For example, whether and how a consumer identifies as an elderly consumer is likely to result in different reactions to age-based transformations and marketing responses, in terms of for example responses to advertising and retail discount offers targeted to elderly consumers.

3.2 | The second theme: Age changes and the elderly consumers

The next theme identified in our analysis focuses on the age changes in consumers. This theme is also discussed in many of the articles that mainly contribute to the other two themes, but then to a lesser degree. Research topics identified within this theme are cognitive changes with age, vulnerability and consumption ensembles, and reactions to aging.

3.2.1 | Cognitive changes with age

The most common research topic in this theme examines the cognitive changes that occur throughout old age. Many of these articles are based on research and theories about aging from cognitive psychology (which also contributes to separating these articles from the articles listed in the research topics above). Common topics are how age-related cognitive changes negatively affect consumer information processing and decision making. Some articles document the differences in information processing between young adults and old adults, such as the sources of information they use and their ability to learn (Phillips & Sternthal, 1977). Elderly consumers rely more on heuristic processing of information than do younger adults and tend to seek out less information before making decisions (Yoon et al., 2009). It is not clear why elderly consumers spontaneously use “deep processing” less and search for less information than younger consumers, whether it is because of the decline in their processing abilities or because they are not as motivated (Cole & Balasubramanian, 1993; Cole & Houston, 1987). The information processing of elderly consumers can be improved with training and the use of perceptual aids (Cole & Balasubramanian, 1993; Cole & Gaeth, 1990). The information processing of elderly consumers is affected by task environments, such as the quantity of information and information format (John & Cole, 1986). Elderly consumers also process and remember

information more efficiently early in the day as opposed to later in the afternoon or evening (Yoon, 1997).

In terms of misleading information, such as misleading advertising claims, elderly consumers are more susceptible to this than are younger consumers (Gaeth & Heath, 1987). When it comes to the memory capacity of elderly consumers, there does not seem to be that many changes in semantic memory in older age, but there is a decline in episodic memory (Yoon et al., 2009). For example, elderly consumers may remember some information, but not the source of it (Yoon et al., 2005). Long-term memory, working memory, and explicit memory performance are also impaired with age (Yoon et al., 2005). Elderly consumers tend to remember pictures and pictorial cues better than text (Yoon et al., 2009), and they place more importance on emotions and subsequently remember emotional information better than non-emotional information (Yoon et al., 2009).

The information processing and memory of elderly consumers affect their decision making. Yoon et al. (2009) summarized much of the research about consumer decision making and aging in a review article and proposed a framework in which the degree of fit between the task and its contextual environment (e.g., familiarity of the task and time of day) and the individual characteristics of the elderly consumer (e.g., age, motivation, and knowledge) affect the effectiveness of their decision making. If the fit is low, consumers risk making decisions that have negative outcomes on an individual and societal level. In response to comments on this article, the authors agreed that the original framework may have indicated a too pessimistic view and later revised it to include a more nuanced (less negative) description of the effects of cognitive changes on decision making (Cole et al., 2009).

In summary, many of the articles in this research topic review differences between older and younger consumers and conclude that there is a cognitive decline that negatively affects the information processing, memory, and decision making of elderly consumers. Some articles, however, emphasize that there are large differences between individual consumers. Some elderly consumers perform just as well as younger adults, while others show a significant decline in their cognitive abilities (Yoon et al., 2005).

3.2.2 | Vulnerability and consumption ensembles

The second research topic in this theme focuses on the vulnerability and physical ability of elderly consumers. Although fewer articles focus on this topic, declining ability and increasing vulnerability are still often discussed in research about elderly consumers. It is also a cause for many public policy concerns about elderly consumers (Goldberg, 2009). Many victims of fraud, such as telemarketing fraud, are elderly consumers (Yoon et al., 2009). However, Berg (2015) emphasized that there are large individual differences and that the entire group should not be considered vulnerable. Of course, the vulnerability and ability of consumers is related to factors like their health status and how advanced in age they are. Relatedly, Ford et al. (2016) described some of the difficulties that elderly consumers experience

when interacting with the packaging of products, such as problems with reading labels and opening the packaging of products. Elderly consumers can for example experience problems with reading labels on product packaging, transporting the products home, opening the packaging, and disposing of the packaging after use. Griffiths and Harmon (2011) also discuss consumer vulnerability in terms of whether age-related changes can impede the ability of elderly consumers to fully interpret informed consent in service situations.

In the later stages of old age, many elderly consumers rely on what Barnhart and Peñaloza (2013) call elderly consumption ensembles. Such ensembles constitute groups of people, such as relatives, friends, or paid service providers, that give regular (or even constant) assistance to the elderly consumers. Consumption thus becomes a group phenomenon carried out in part vicariously by others on behalf of the elderly consumer, rather than (as in earlier life) an individual phenomenon. Consumption decisions and life changes are also influenced by people surrounding the elderly consumers, such as children and physicians, leading researchers to advice that services should also be promoted to family members and health care workers (Gibler et al., 1998). In some regions, such as in rural Japan, support services are also carried out by nonprofit organizations and residents' associations, based on local relationships rather than relationships based on family or health care (Ho & Shirahada, 2020).

Much of the literature on elderly consumers' vulnerability and ability thus focuses on vulnerability without discussing how it may be connected to ability. Ability is mostly discussed in connection to other research topics, such as how elderly consumers relate to new technologies or sustainability. A recent example is LaBarge and Pyle (2020), who examined how elderly consumers employ marketplace resources to maximize their quality of life, independence, and general wellbeing.

3.2.3 | Reactions to aging

The third research topic in this theme focuses on how the elderly react to aging in their role as consumers. Only four articles focus on this topic, but as these articles were published recently, this indicates a current research interest in these issues. The first article, by Groeppel-Klein et al. (2017), found negative effects from exposure to negative age stereotypes on the cognitive performance of older consumers. Just like exposure to other types of stereotypes, it seems that being primed with age stereotypes has a negative effect on the cognitive performance of older consumers in decision-making situations. Negative age stereotypes can also affect other consumption behaviors in elderly consumers. Bae et al. (2018) showed that elderly consumers may purchase antiaging products to cope with stress after being exposed to negative age stereotypes. Moscato and Ozanne (2019) described a more experiential reaction to aging in elderly female consumers. The authors described how elderly female consumers engage in rebellious eating through membership in the Red Hat Society. Members in the (all-female) society regularly gather in restaurants to indulge in food and alcohol in ways that the authors described as going against the strict social norm of how older women

should behave (e.g., eating their dessert first). Loroz (2004) studied how elderly consumers engages in gambling and propose that this, like other forms of experiential consumption, may reinforce and enhance the self-concepts of the elderly consumers.

3.2.4 | Discussion of the second theme: Age changes and the elderly consumers

The second theme identified in our analysis focuses on age changes and how these affect the elderly in their role as consumers. The emphasis in this literature is on differences between elderly consumers and other (younger) consumer groups (rather than similarities within the group, as in the first theme). The many similarities between the groups are seldom dwelt upon and few articles focus on any differences within the (large and in many ways heterogeneous) group of elderly consumers. It is at times also difficult to say whether differences between the groups really depend on age changes or if they are cohort effects. For example, the level of education will differ between younger and older cohorts, something that can affect the ability to solve problems used to test cognitive abilities (Yoon, 1997). The articles about this theme are often based on findings from other disciplines such as psychology and gerontology. This may explain why cognitive age changes are explored in much more detail (and in many more articles) than other psychological and physiological changes. This focus may be problematic because consumer vulnerability and ability can influence consumption just as much, if not more, than cognitive abilities. If some elderly consumers cannot, for example, read the text that is written on a product, how they would process the text will not matter at all.

3.3 | The third theme: Marketing responses of elderly consumers

The third theme in our analysis relates to how consumers respond to different aspects of marketing. A large majority of the articles in our analysis focus on topics related to this theme (129 articles). The seven research topics that we identified in this area are how elderly consumers respond to: advertising, brands, services, retailing, tourism, new technologies, and sustainability.

3.3.1 | Elderly consumers and advertising

Although elderly consumers have been studied for a long time in advertising research, there are few articles about this research topic in our literature review. Some research has focused on how elderly consumers respond to emotional advertising appeals. As mentioned, elderly consumers tend to place more importance on emotions and remember emotional information better (Yoon et al., 2009). This tendency affects how they respond to emotional appeals in advertising. In general, elderly consumers like and recall ads featuring emotional

appeals better than younger consumers do (Williams & Drolet, 2005). For younger consumers, ads with emotional appeals are only preferred for hedonic (vs. utilitarian) products, but elderly consumers prefer them for both types of products (Drolet et al., 2007). However, if perceptions of time horizon length are limited (this can, for example, be manipulated by including statements like "life is short" in the copy of an ad), both elderly and younger consumers prefer emotional appeals (Williams & Drolet, 2005). There are also differences in how elderly consumers respond to emotional appeal ads that focus on avoiding negative emotions and achieving positive emotions. Williams and Drolet (2005) showed that elderly consumers display more positive attitudes toward ads which focus on avoiding negative emotions, except for when their time horizon length is expanded. Conversely, younger consumers have more positive attitudes toward ads that focus on achieving positive emotions, except when their time horizon length is limited.

3.3.2 | Elderly consumers and brands

A small number of articles study how elderly consumers respond to brands. The brand relationships and purchases of elderly consumers seem to differ from those of younger consumers. In a large empirical study of repeat purchases made by elderly consumers, Lambert-Pandraud et al. (2005) found that they consider fewer brands, stores, and products before a repurchase. Elderly consumers also select brands that have been established for a longer period of time than the brands considered by the younger consumer groups. Lambert-Pandraud and Laurent (2010) also examined the motivations of older consumers in buying brands that have been established for a longer period of time. Their findings show that elderly consumers tend to remain attached to the same brands for longer durations and that there is a limited effect of nostalgia for "old" brands encountered earlier in life. There are also differences in brand usage within age groups, so that among both older and younger consumers, some change brands frequently while others remain loyal. Phua et al. (2020) recently examined the use of older and newer brands in a large empirical study of the grocery purchases made by elderly consumers. Their results did not replicate those of previous studies but show that elderly consumers do not purchase older brands more often than they purchase younger brands. Consumer emotions also seem to play a role in brand attachments, especially in elderly women who display more emotional brand attachment processes than other consumers (Jahn et al., 2012).

3.3.3 | Elderly consumers and services

Another research topic that has received some research attention is how elderly consumers respond to services. Services are more important to the elderly than to younger consumer groups. Elderly consumers make a larger share of their expenditures on services and evaluate services more in terms of the social benefits that they derive

from them (Grougiou & Pettigrew, 2011). Service encounters also play a greater role in maintaining the wellbeing of elderly consumers (Plaud & Guillemot, 2015). Shopping constitutes an important social activity for elderly consumers (Grougiou & Pettigrew, 2011; Kang & Ridgway, 1996), and their responses to service encounters differ from those of younger consumers (Lumpkin & Hite, 1988). Due to fewer social interactions in general, however, elderly consumers receive and engage less in word-of-mouth communication, something that may contribute to their comparative brand loyalty and low levels of brand switching and information-seeking behavior (East et al., 2014). Emotions play a greater role in how elderly consumers respond to service failures. Babin et al. (2021) recently demonstrated that the behavioral responses of elderly consumers to perceived justice in service failure situations, in terms of forgiveness, is dependent on their emotional responses. Due to learned helplessness, elderly consumers are less likely to complain when they are dissatisfied with services (LaForge, 1989). Several articles about this research topic are focused on specific services, such as health care services (Sirgy et al., 1991) and restaurant services (Lee et al., 2012). Some articles also focus on financial services and explore the preferences and behavior of elderly consumers in relation to financial services (Moschis et al., 2003).

3.3.4 | Elderly consumers and retailing

Another set of articles is focused on how elderly consumers respond to different aspects of retailing. This is the largest research topic in this theme. Some of these articles focus on general responses to retailing of the elderly consumer group. In retail contexts, elderly consumers seem to view older sales personnel more positively than they do younger sales personnel, and retail firms and sales personnel are less accurate in assessing the preferences and satisfaction of elderly consumers (Johnson-Hillery et al., 1997). Elderly consumers are, however, not a homogenous group in terms of behaviors and preferences related to retailing (Kohijoki & Marjanen, 2013). A number of articles attempt to define market segments which respond similarly to different aspects of retailing using methods like gerontographics (Moschis et al., 2004, 2011) and psychographics (Oates et al., 1996). Several of the articles also attempt to define segments of elderly consumers with regard to specific retail contexts (Burt & Gabbott, 1995; Oates et al., 1996; Teller & Gittenberger, 2011). Several articles specifically focus on fashion retailing, a product category in which elderly consumers are still very interested but in which the needs of the elderly market are often ignored (Greco, 1986; Thomas & Peters, 2009; Townsend et al., 2019). Elderly consumers are also still very interested in cosmetics products, but the elderly consumer group is often neglected by retailers and marketers in this area (Baek, 2020). Another set of articles study elderly consumers and their grocery shopping behavior (Kohijoki, 2011; Meneely, Strugnell, et al., 2009; Yin et al., 2013). Like services, shopping for groceries can be an important social activity for elderly consumers (Oeser et al., 2018). In-store interactions with staff are also especially important to this consumer group (Pettigrew et al., 2005). Other topics related to retailing in the

analyzed articles were the store choices of elderly consumers (Moschis et al., 2004, 2011) and the perceived importance to the group of various retail attributes (Oates et al., 1996).

3.3.5 | Elderly consumers and tourism

Elderly consumers are not only described as a growing segment of interest and importance for the travel and hospitality industry (Pestana et al., 2020; Tiago et al., 2016), but there is also a growing literature highlighting the importance of travel later in life (Moal, 2021; Pestana et al., 2020; Sie et al., 2021). The literature also predicts the need for new tourism products to better satisfy the growing segment of elderly consumers (Glover & Prideaux, 2009). In the articles about this research topic, many correspond, however, to the first theme in our analysis and are focused on describing and defining the elderly market segment and its subsegments within tourism, often for commercial purposes (Tiago et al., 2016). Mathur et al. (1998) described opportunities for the marketing of travel services to the elderly based on a value-orientated segmentation. Other studies have sought to better understand elderly consumers by comparing them to other age groups (Lehto et al., 2008). Another stream of research is focused on the motives and behaviors of elderly consumers in travel and hospitality. Cognitive age or subjective age are used to explain the motivations of elderly tourists (Le Serre et al., 2017), as are sociodemographic characteristics (Kim & Kim, 2020) and personal health (Hunter-Jones & Blackburn, 2007; Kim & Kim, 2020). A recent study (Pestana et al., 2020) found that motivations differ between younger and older elderly consumers, so that the younger value expansion factors oriented toward enlarging and enriching quality of life and the older value maintenance factors oriented toward maintaining a lifestyle. Tourism marketing toward elderly consumers should thus differ depending on the intended target age group. For example, Le Serre and Chevalier (2012) found that the discrepancy age (the gap between cognitive age and ideal age) is a useful segmentation tool for the elderly market.

3.3.6 | Elderly consumers and new technologies

Mirroring the increasing research interest in technology and adoption of innovations, most articles on this topic were published after 2000. Earlier works suggest that previous familiarity with related technologies explain differences in the adoption behavior between older and younger consumers (Gilly & Zeithaml, 1985). Later, the focus on characteristics of the elderly consumers gave way to more interest in the process of adoption (Choudrie et al., 2020) and some articles note the importance of social aspects, such as family members' roles in the adoption of technology (Mathur, 1999; cf. Hough & Kobylanski, 2009). Several articles explore consumer behavior specifically related to the Internet (Reisenwitz et al., 2007), technologies in general, or mobile technologies in particular (Laukkanen et al., 2007; Nikou, 2015). Digital banking has also received some research interest (Chaouali & Souiden, 2019). Artificial intelligence

has so far only been investigated in the form of virtual agents (Chattaraman et al., 2011), and digital marketing and social media related to elderly consumers has only very recently been explored (Nunan & Di Domenico, 2019; Pera et al., 2020). Interestingly, Nunan and Di Domenico (2019) noted that most of the previous literature has been focused on negative aspects of the elderly and technology. Reviewing the existing literature, these aspects include innovation/technology resistance (Bae et al., 2021; Gilly & Zeithaml, 1985; Hough & Kobylanski, 2009), risk aversion (Reisenwitz et al., 2007), and technology anxiety (Meuter et al., 2003). These negative responses to technology are found to correspond to the future time perspectives of elderly consumers, so that consumers who perceive that their future time is limited (as opposed to expansive) are less likely to use self-service technologies (Park et al., 2021). Only lately have more positive aspects been indicated, such as the dispelling of stereotypes about elderly consumers (Choudrie et al., 2020; Pera et al., 2020) and a shift in focus toward opportunities for value creation (Nunan & Di Domenico, 2019; Pera et al., 2020) and wellbeing (Bianchi, 2021).

3.3.7 | Elderly consumers and sustainability

Sustainability is one of the smallest research topics in our analysis. All the articles on this topic investigate the pro-environmental behavior of elderly consumers and were published between 2012 and 2020, indicating that a new field of research may be emerging. The first article investigates potential cross-national differences among elderly consumers (Sudbury Riley et al., 2012) and find that sociodemographic factors should be replaced by actual purchases of ecological products as indicators of other ecologically conscious consumer behavior. However, a recent article shows that chronological age is an indicator of involvement in and purchases of ecofriendly food in that the behavior increases with age up to 50–59 years old after which it declines (Nam, 2020). Chronological age was also found to be only an indirect influence on recycling behavior (Guiot et al., 2019), which is in line with the increased acceptance in the literature that age is only a descriptive variable for the physiological, psychological, and sociological processes connected with aging (Moschis, 2012). Kim and Jin (2019) also based their research on elderly women but find that their time perspective combined with their fashion consciousness predict the consumption of environmentally sustainable apparel.

3.3.8 | Discussion of the third theme: Marketing responses of elderly consumers

The third theme focuses on the responses of elderly consumers to different aspects of marketing, as well as their subsequent behavior in relation to the marketing (e.g., purchasing behavior or consumption patterns). The articles focusing on this theme are representative of consumer marketing research articles in that consumer responses to different aspects of marketing are examined. This research often builds on research from the two prior themes, such as findings about

cognitive differences between the elderly consumers and other groups. In this theme too, the focus lies on exploring differences between consumer groups rather than examining similarities between consumer groups or differences within the elderly consumer group. In retailing and tourism, for example, many articles are focused on finding and describing market segments, as well as making recommendations about how to serve and market toward these segments. In other areas, such as research on new technologies, research is moving toward finding similarities between the elderly consumer group and other age groups. Dispelling stereotypes about elderly consumers (e.g., that elderly consumers are reluctant to use new technologies) is a topic that seems to have attracted more research interest lately. This research topic also relates to some of the research on old age identity. Finally, many of the research articles contributing to this theme are very specific, in that they focus exclusively on specific sectors or geographical regions. Their findings thus mainly apply to that specific context, rather than making more general contributions to the research literature about elderly consumers in marketing research. In the more recent articles within this theme, however, there seems to be a degree of overlapping between the research topics. This indicates that there may be a research opportunity in combining several of the research topics moving forward, such as advertising for retailers, or responses to sustainable advertising and brands.

4 | THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

In our review of the marketing research on elderly consumers, we identified and defined three overarching themes that will help guide future research in the area. Our literature review will also help make this rich and varied marketing research literature more accessible to researchers and practitioners alike. The themes that we have identified in the research are interlinked and have been simultaneously developed over time. If there is a trend here, it is that the research focus has shifted from describing the consumer group (first theme) to studying their responses to specific aspects of marketing (third theme). This seems like a natural progression, because to understand how elderly consumers respond to something, it is necessary to understand who they are and how age changes make them different from other groups. Based on the marketing responses of the elderly consumer group, much can also be learned about who they are as a large and heterogeneous group and what aging as a consumer implies. The themes also differ in what the object of study is in the research articles. In the first theme, the focus is on studying the consumer group or individuals in it. The second theme focuses more on the process of aging and related age changes, while the third theme focuses on the responses of elderly consumers to different aspects of marketing. The theoretical framework is summarized and illustrated in Figure 3.

5 | DIRECTIONS FOR FUTURE RESEARCH

Based on the literature review and the theoretical framework proposed in this paper, we formulated a set of directions for future

research. Below, these research directions are outlined for each of the three themes identified in the systematic literature review. These research directions are also summarized in Table 4 below. One overarching recommendation for future research, regardless of theme or research topic, is that there is a need for research from more geographical regions. This recommendation is based on our geographical analysis of all the articles included in our review (as illustrated in Table 2 above). Out of 209 articles, 110 are based on data collected in the U.S. (or, in the articles that do not report empirical findings, authored by researchers residing in the U.S.). Some of the findings presented in these articles are likely to be generalizable across countries, such as studies investigating the cognitive functions of elderly consumers. Other findings, however, are likely to differ across geographical regions and would therefore need to be replicated in other geographical and cultural contexts. Examples of such research that would be of particular interest are analyses of consumption patterns, elderly consumer behaviors, and other marketing responses that are likely to be culturally dependent.

5.1 | Future research directions for the first theme: Describing and defining the elderly consumer group

Many of the research articles contributing to the first theme, describing the elderly consumer group, were published several decades ago. In future research on this topic, it would therefore be valuable to replicate some of this earlier research. Many of the articles focusing on describing the elderly as a marketing segment were focused on describing specific cohorts of elderly consumers, such as the silent generation or the early baby boomers (Ferguson & Brohaugh, 2010; Fox & French, 1985; Greco, 1987). Thus, future research on this topic may want to describe new cohorts currently entering the elderly consumer group. Many of the articles in our analysis point out that elderly consumers are not a homogenous group, and that research needs to consider factors like generations and cohorts, cognitive age, future time perspective, and age groups (e.g., young-old and old-old). The discourse in the research literature also seems to be moving from static descriptions of elderly consumers as a homogenous market segment and how this differs from other segments to a more heterogeneous and dynamic view of aging. After all, aging is not a market segment as much as it is a process involving all consumers all the time. Future research on this topic should also consider implications of the changing demographics of many countries today. In many places, populations are aging rapidly, and the growth of the elderly consumer group will have implications for marketers and researchers alike. It seems natural that marketing research should follow suit, so that there will be an increased interest in describing the development of the elderly consumer group. It would also be very useful if future research were to include more information about the actual financial situations and consumption patterns of elderly consumers, as most of the extant literature argue that elderly consumers are important due to the size of their consumer segment, rather than their actual and potential spending power.

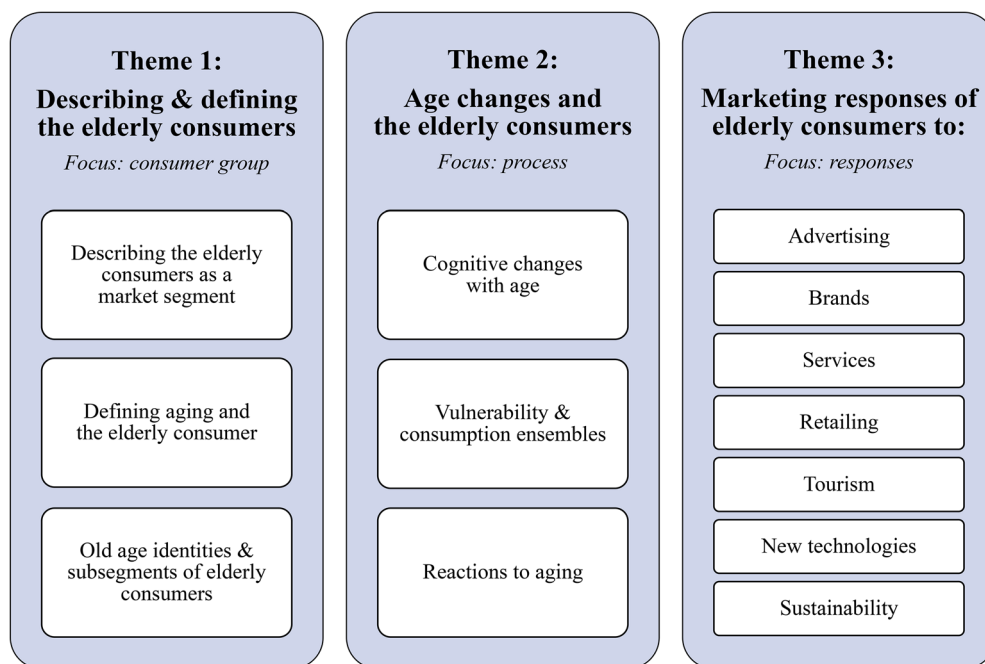


FIGURE 3 Theoretical framework illustrating the themes and research topics identified in the research on elderly consumers in marketing

In terms of the second research topic in this theme, defining aging and the elderly consumer, there is a clear development in the recent literature where researchers are increasingly seeing aging as a process, transformation, or even a construct (Kuppelwieser & Klaus, 2020). This is a useful perspective that allows for a better understanding of what happens to us all as we become older consumers. It also allows for a more dynamic view of elderly consumers in society, as well as in marketing research. In contrast to this, the earlier research on this topic focused more on defining the elderly consumer group in terms of their chronological age or cohort (Dann, 2007; Schewe, 1988). Other research examined cognitive age (Amatulli et al., 2018; Catterall & Maclaran, 2001) and future time perspective (FTP; Kuppelwieser & Klaus, 2020) as constructs that help define the elderly consumer group. Future research will want to integrate these different ways of defining the elderly consumers group. Definitions of the elderly consumer group need to consider the current research in the field, advocating for more fluid definitions and moving away from a focus on chronological age. However, the definitions also need to be tangible enough to offer practical guidance for marketers and marketing researchers who want to focus on this large and important consumer group.

The articles focusing on the third research topic in this theme, old age identities and subsegments of elderly consumers, explored consumer identities and roles in the elderly consumer group. As societal views and attitudes about aging and the elderly change in line with an aging population and new generational cohorts entering the group, the roles and identities assumed by elderly consumers will likely also change. Future research on this topic should thus examine current developments in sub-cultures and roles among the elderly consumer group, in terms of how this will affect old age identities in the group. Representations of cultural memory in elderly consumers may be useful to consider here, as this provides a means for exploring aging

(Blake et al., 2018). We also believe that this research topic could be further enriched by the intersection between age and, for example, gender or race (Blake et al., 2018; Gopaldas & Siebert, 2018; Gurrieri, 2021; Moscato & Ozanne, 2019), as old age identity might very well provide different routes of transformation for different groups of elderly consumers.

5.2 | Future research directions for the second theme: Age changes and the elderly consumers

Much of the research contributing to the second theme, age changes and the elderly consumers, is based on research in other disciplines. Future research contributing to this theme will therefore want to reflect developments in these other research fields, such as psychology and gerontology.

Most of the research on the first research topic contributing to this theme, cognitive changes with age, is based on research in the field of cognitive psychology. Findings from this field about topics like decision making (Yoon et al., 2009) and memory (Yoon et al., 2005) have here been applied to marketing research about elderly consumers. Future research on this topic should therefore closely follow recent and future research developments in the cognitive psychology field. Future research in this area will also hopefully move away from the implicit assumption that elderly consumers are somehow inferior to younger consumers (for example, in terms of cognitive processing; Yoon et al., 2009). As the current literature on elderly consumers is already moving away from its early focus on the negative aspects of aging, future research should follow suit. A more balanced outlook may, for example, lead to a greater degree of investigation of value creation in the process of aging and how this can lead to outcomes such as increased wellbeing among elderly consumers.

TABLE 4 List of suggestions for future research on elderly consumers, grouped into themes and research topics

Themes	Research topics	Future research suggestions
Theme 1: Describing & defining the elderly consumer group	Describing the elderly consumers as a market segment	• Replicate earlier research to include new cohorts and demographical developments. • Explore the heterogeneity of the elderly consumer group and its implications. • Include multinational samples and increase the cultural awareness of future research. • Include understudied markets, especially in countries where there are fewer elderly consumers.
	Defining aging and the elderly consumer	• Study the elderly consumer group based on a view of aging in line with an ongoing process or transformation. • Study the elderly consumer group based on other defining variables than chronological age, such as future time perspective and cognitive age. • Propose new definitions of the group that are useful for both researchers and practitioners.
	Old age identities & subsegments of elderly consumers	• Add to the limited research about old age identity in elderly consumers and its effects. • Study new roles and sub-cultures emerging in the elderly consumer group. • Study the effects of new roles and sub-cultures on elderly consumers and their consumption. • Study effects of intersectionality between age and e.g., gender and race.
Theme 2: Age changes and the elderly consumers	Cognitive changes with age	• Apply current and future research in cognitive psychology to the study of elderly consumers. • Examine the heterogeneity among elderly consumers in terms of their cognitive age changes. • Study more positive aspects of cognitive changes with age in elderly consumers.
	Vulnerability & consumption ensembles	• Apply current research in gerontology to the context of elderly consumers. • Study elderly consumers from an ableness perspective, based on related ableness research. • Examine whether innovative technological solutions, such as AI and voice control, could be useful to elderly consumers with vulnerability and in consumption ensembles.
	Reactions to aging	• Study the role of age stereotypes in how elderly consumers react to aging. • Study how marketing can help alleviate negative reactions to aging in elderly consumers.
Theme 3: Marketing responses of elderly consumers	Elderly consumers and advertising	• Examine the responses of elderly consumers to more advertising appeals. • Include the elderly consumer group in more advertising research study samples.
	Elderly consumers and brands	• Examine whether elderly consumers still respond differently to brands than younger consumers. • Resolve whether elderly consumers are more brand loyal and prefer older brands or not.
	Elderly consumers and services	• Study the responses of elderly consumers to service encounters. • Study factors contributing to customer satisfaction with service encounters in elderly consumers.
	Elderly consumers and retailing	• Study factors contributing to customer satisfaction with retailers and stores in elderly consumers. • Combine research fields such as elderly consumers in retailing and new technologies or services. • Study how crises such as the COVID-19 pandemic affect elderly consumers' responses to retailing.
	Elderly consumers and tourism	• Study the responses of elderly consumers to service encounters in tourism. • Study factors contributing to customer wellbeing and value creation through traveling and tourism.
	Elderly consumers and new technologies	• Explore how innovative technology (e.g., AI, voice control) can benefit elderly consumers. • Study the responses of elderly consumers to new technology.
	Elderly consumers and sustainability	• Explore differences in sustainable behavior between elderly consumers and other groups. • Study how marketing can be used to promote sustainable behavior in elderly consumers.

In our literature review, we found fewer articles on the second research topic contributing to this theme, on vulnerability and consumption ensembles. Considering the growth of the elderly consumer group, both their abilities and vulnerabilities in their role as consumers need to be examined more closely and more research in this area is thus needed. Many of the articles covering this research topic are based on research in gerontology, and/or centers on ableness issues (Berg, 2015). Future research on this topic should therefore strive to apply more of the current research findings from these rich and interdisciplinary research fields. Findings from research in other fields about the vulnerabilities of the elderly should also be examined in the context of elderly consumers. Another interesting research area would be whether new technology, such as AI and voice control, could be used to facilitate the lives of elderly consumers, both reducing vulnerability and increasing ability in elderly consumers. The articles relating to consumption as a collective activity are also grounded in gerontology and ableness research (Barnhart & Peñaloza, 2013). This is thus likely to be a fruitful area for research on how new technology can transform the consumption taking place in consumption ensembles (Barnhart & Peñaloza, 2013), or different types of assisted consumption (Ho & Shirahada, 2020).

Further, there is a need for more knowledge about how suffering losses, such as a significant person, home, or pet can affect consumption patterns and consumer behavior at large. This is also connected to the COVID-19 pandemic, which affected many elderly consumers (e.g., Sattari & Billore, 2020). Our literature review did, however, not include any research specifically on this topic, because no such articles that met our search criteria (e.g., articles published in journals listed in the Academic Journal Guide) were published before the cut-off date of our article search (April 2021). There may have been articles on this topic in other research fields and journals at the time, but these would have been outside of the scope of the present review.

Finally, the articles on the third research topic, reactions to aging, are more recent and our hope is that they represent the start of a new area of research. Future research may want to examine how marketing could help alleviate and counter negative reactions to aging in elderly consumers. Mirroring the development in marketing research overall, there is also a promising path for research on elderly consumers to become more inclusive and diverse. One way to achieve this would be to avoid the use of age stereotypes and static segmenting of elderly consumers and to continue the investigation of the effects of stereotypes of elderly consumers (Bae et al., 2018; Groeppel-Klein et al., 2017). As we noted in our analysis of the second theme, few articles have studied negative reactions to aging and age stereotypes in consumers, which should thus be a promising area for future research. Similarly, age stereotypes are often complex, combining more than one set of stereotypes, and future research should therefore consider examining an intersectionality of stereotypes concerning, for example, age, gender, and race (Gopaldas & Siebert, 2018).

5.3 | Future research directions for the third theme: Marketing responses of elderly consumers

The articles contributing to the third theme in our framework are focused on the marketing responses of elderly consumers. In all research topics included in this theme, more research is needed. Many research topics remain understudied or have not been studied at all in marketing research. Many of the older studies also need to be replicated, as they were carried out already several decades ago. Specifically, future attempts to replicate studies included in this review would indicate whether the previous findings are tied to specific earlier cohorts of consumers or if generalizations to later cohorts can be made. In terms of marketing research about the first topic in this theme, elderly consumers and advertising, this is still a relatively small and underdeveloped area of research. Some of the articles in our literature review on this topic focused on the responses to emotional advertising appeals (Drolet et al., 2007; Williams & Drolet, 2005) in elderly consumers, but future research should also examine responses to other advertising appeals in the consumer group. Not much is known about how this large and important consumer group responds to advertising, because most advertising research is focused on younger consumer groups, such as the millennials. Future research might also want to investigate how elderly consumers respond to new forms of (digital) advertising, thereby continuing the work of Nunan and Di Domenico (2019).

There were even fewer articles in our review about the second topic in this theme, elderly consumers and brands. Interestingly, the research in this area provided some contradictory findings. Some of the articles in our analysis showed that elderly consumers differ from younger consumer groups in that they are more brand loyal and prefer older brands (Lambert-Pandraud et al., 2005; Lambert-Pandraud & Laurent, 2010), but Phua et al. (2020) contradict these findings, finding no differences between the age groups. Future research should investigate the implications of these new findings and examine whether the differences are due to contextual factors (e.g., type of products, cultural context) or to changes in the elderly consumer group (e.g., new generational cohorts entering the group). The articles about the third research topic in this theme, elderly consumers and services, indicate that services are more important to elderly consumers than to other consumer groups (Grougiou & Pettigrew, 2011; Plaud & Guillemot, 2015), but also that their responses to services can differ from those of other consumers (Lumpkin & Hite, 1988). There is, however, no research about how service encounters should be designed to suit elderly consumers, or about what aspects of service encounters are most important for the customer satisfaction of this consumer group. It is also possible that responses to service encounters in the elderly consumer group will develop differently over the coming years, when even more services are digitalized, and new cohorts enter the elderly consumer group. For example, many financial services and healthcare services have been digitized, whereas other service areas remain mostly unchanged (e.g., the services provided in most restaurants).

The fourth research topic in this theme, elderly consumers and retailing, was studied in many articles in our literature review, but the articles are scattered over a large number of topics and the studies reported in them were often carried out in limited geographical settings with small samples. The findings from the articles on this topic show that retailers have insufficient knowledge about the consumer group to assess their customer satisfaction (Johnson-Hillery et al., 1997) and the most important retail attributes to the group (Oates et al., 1996). Future research could examine the customer satisfaction and preferences of the elderly consumer group related to retailing further. There is also an opportunity here for conducting research in the intersection of retail and other research topics, such as new retail technologies and service technologies. Another research question of interest would be how retailers have adapted to meet the needs of elderly consumers during the COVID-19 pandemic. In many ways, the research on the fifth research topic, elderly consumers and tourism, is similar to the research about elderly consumers and retailing. Although not dating as far back in time, the research on elderly consumers as tourists and travelers has been carried out in many varied and specific contexts, limiting its ability to provide generalizable conclusions. Future research should therefore replicate some of the research in this area with larger and more diverse samples, as well as with new cohorts, as these enter the market, and the tourism sector develops and changes over time. Future research could also apply some of the findings from the research about elderly consumers and brands, to examine whether this group stays loyal or changes tourism and travel brands more or less frequently than other consumer groups (Phua et al., 2020). Other interesting research topics for future research would be how the wellbeing of elderly consumers can be increased through tourism and which aspects of tourism are most important for the consumer group (Pestana et al., 2020). Future research should also examine the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic in relation to elderly consumers in tourism.

In terms of research on elderly consumers and new technologies, there is a need for more research investigating how technologies can assist elderly consumers (e.g., increase ability and reduce vulnerability) and how elderly consumers respond to new technologies. As noted by Nunan and Di Domenico (2019), future research should pay less attention to the negative implications of introducing new technology for elderly consumers and focus more on its potential to provide wellbeing (Bianchi, 2021) and value creation (Nunan & Di Domenico, 2019; Pera et al., 2020) for the group. This is increasingly important as new cohorts, who are likely to be more educated and used to a fast-paced technological development, enter the elderly consumer group. We believe that research on AI and voice control can be particularly interesting here, especially for those elderly consumers who may otherwise rely completely on consumption ensembles (Barnhart & Peñaloza, 2013). Finally, our last research topic, elderly consumers and sustainability, provides a fertile ground for future research. As the relative size of the elderly consumer group increases, it becomes increasingly important for this consumer group to adapt to a more sustainable consumption. Chronological age only

partially influences pro-environmental behavior (Guiot et al., 2019), while other physiological, psychological, and sociological processes involved in aging (Moschis, 2012) also help explain, predict, and affect sustainable behavior. The positive responses of elderly consumers to emotional advertising appeals (Drolet et al., 2007; Williams & Drolet, 2005) may indicate that marketing communication messages using advertising appeals targeted specifically to this group could be an effective technique to promote more sustainable consumption in it.

6 | CONCLUSION

The marketing research on elderly consumers reviewed in this paper can be described as a niche stream of marketing research, but a niche research stream that is both rich and fragmented. In most marketing research, however, elderly consumers are seldom included in studies and analyses. Based on our literature review, we would argue that including an age perspective on marketing research is just as relevant as, for example, a gender perspective. As our literature review shows, there are large gaps in the extant knowledge about elderly consumers, gaps that we hope that future research will be able to address. Our specific suggestions for future research have been outlined in section 5 and is summarized in Table 4, organized by theme and research topics. In terms of more general recommendations for future research, we propose three overarching research directions, based on our literature review. The first direction is that research on elderly consumers should not only attempt to produce new knowledge, but also to replicate previous research. As new cohorts enter the elderly consumer group and new technologies change many areas of marketing and consumption, some of the previous research findings will need to be reevaluated. The second research direction we propose is that the marketing research on elderly consumers needs to develop in tandem with other research fields, such as psychology, gerontology, and technology. Moving forward, it is important to continually introduce the latest research findings from other disciplines to the marketing research on elderly consumers. A third, and final direction for future research is to aim for a more geographically and culturally diverse research stream. Consumer research increasingly includes a global perspective in terms of both cultural awareness and multinational samples (Merz et al., 2008; Sudbury Riley et al., 2012, 2015; cf. Craig & Douglas, 2001), something that is largely missing in the marketing research on elderly consumers. Large portions of the world now have a population where less than 10 percent are aged 65 or over (United Nations, 2019). It would seem likely that consumer aging would be different in those countries. Extending this field of research over time would likely create a new research opportunity in exploring consumer aging in countries where the share of elderly consumers has previously been small.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST

The authors have no conflict of interest to declare.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing not applicable to this article as no datasets were generated or analysed during the current study.

ORCID

Hanna Berg  <https://orcid.org/0000-0003-2956-1701>

Karina T. Liljedal  <https://orcid.org/0000-0003-4106-4310>

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AUTHOR BIOGRAPHIES

Hanna Berg is an associate professor at the Center for Consumer Marketing, Stockholm School of Economics. Her main research interests are consumer behavior, visual marketing, advertising, and online retailing. Berg's work has been published in journals such as *Journal of Business Research*, *Psychology & Marketing*, *European Journal of Marketing*, *Journal of Service Management*, and *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*.

Karina T. Liljedal is an assistant professor at the Center for Consumer Marketing and a research fellow at the Center for Retailing at Stockholm School of Economics. Her research interests are consumer behavior, advertising, and retail. Liljedal's work has been published in journals such as *Journal of Advertising Research*, *European Journal of Marketing*, *Journal of Marketing Communications*, and *International Review of Retail, Distribution and Consumer Research*.

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